

1.9. Printers

A computer printer, or more commonly a printer, produces a hard copy (permanent human-readable text and/or graphics) of documents stored in electronic form, usually on physical print media such as paper or transparencies. Many printers are primarily used as local computer peripherals, and are attached by a printer cable to a computer which serves as a document source.

In addition, many modern printers can directly interface to electronic media such as memory sticks or memory cards, or to image capture devices such as digital cameras and scanners. Some printers are combined with scanners and/or a fax in a single unit. Printers that include non-printing features are sometimes called Multi-Function Printers (MFP) or Multi-Function Devices (MFD).

A printer which is combined with a scanner can function as a photocopier if so designed. Most MFPs include printing, scanning and copying among their features.

A printer's speed is measured in PPM (pages per minute) and resolution in DPI (dots per inch). Resolution refers to the quality of the output of the printer. The greater the resolution, the greater is the quality. Printers use the CMYK colour mode, which offers the combinations of the colours cyan, magenta and yellow in addition to printing black and white (the K in CMYK is for the word black).

Printers are routinely classified by the underlying print technology they employ. Numerous such technologies have been developed over the years.

Toner-based printers work using the Xerographic principle that is at work in most photocopiers—by adhering toner to a light-sensitive print drum, then using static electricity to transfer the toner to the printing medium to which it is fused with heat and pressure.